

Telling yourself the packing will only take a weekend

8 findings · 14-step checklist · 5 sources · cheatgrid.com

Packing runs longer than a weekend, and you'll underestimate it even having done nearly the same job before. Running over doesn't mean you're disorganized.

THE GOAL

You're building a schedule that holds even though your gut number runs short. List every room, then guess evenings per room and add those up.

CHECKLIST

Sitting down, a few weeks out, to count backward from moving day and work out how many evenings packing will take.

- ☐ Write your moving day at the top of a page, then list every room, closet, and storage spot you'll need to pack.
- ☐ Check your calendar for the days you're already busy with work or plans, and cross them off before assigning packing time.
- ☐ Next to each room name, jot down how many evenings you think it alone will take.
- ☐ Add together the evening numbers you gave each room, and let the sum replace whatever guess first popped into your head.
- ☐ If part of this move is new, like a bigger place or a fragile collection, give it its own line in the total.
- ☐ Write your total somewhere you'll actually see it again, like the fridge or a note on your phone.
- ☐ Look up how long your last comparable job, a past move or a big home project, actually took to finish.
- ☐ If that past total runs longer than the one you just built, move your new total up to match it, not down.
- ☐ Add one buffer block at the end of your schedule, sized the way you would if a friend asked what happens if it runs long.
- ☐ Set **one firm date** packing has to be finished by, a few days before moving day itself, not the day the truck arrives.
- ☐ Split your total into blocks and put each on a specific day and time, noting beside the earliest block whatever it needs to be ready.
- ☐ Pick a checkpoint day partway through, and write down now what counts as on track by then, say most rooms boxed.
- ☐ If you're behind at that checkpoint, write now which room's things get boxed as-is, fast, and dealt with once you've moved.
- ☐ Decide now that any date you tell someone else will come from this written total, not a rounder number made up on the spot.

THE THREE BIGGEST THINGS

- 1** You still underestimate a packing job even after doing nearly the same thing before.
- 2** Running past a weekend doesn't mean you're **disorganized**. Even people who finish everything else early run into this.
- 3** Don't treat the date you say out loud to someone else as your real plan. People's spoken predictions ran more optimistic, and less accurate, than the ones they gave without their name attached.

Why your gut number is already wrong

KNOW

You still underestimate a packing job even after doing nearly the same thing before.

You picture how this move should go and write off your past delays as not relevant this time. [Source 1](#)

KNOW

Admitting your last estimate ran short won't fix your next guess.

Your intentions can update; your actual behaviour under a deadline usually doesn't. [Source 2](#)

KNOW

Even a careful, realistic guess about packing time can run short. Fewer than a third of students hit the finish date they had predicted for themselves.

Students' own best guess averaged 33.9 days; the real total came to 55.5. [Source 3](#)

What actually changes the number

DO

Add up separate time estimates for each room instead of guessing the whole move all at once.

Three experiments found this worked, but the source warns it takes real mental effort and isn't easy to keep up daily. [Source 4](#)

DO

Give packing a real deadline, not a private target. People given a tracked due date mostly finished before it, even while their sense of the total time stayed too rosy.

Set a firm cutoff and track it, and your actual pace tends to follow the date more than your original guess. [Source 3](#)

DO

Name the exact day, time, and place you'll pack each block, instead of planning to get to it sometime. People who did this started sooner and hit fewer interruptions once they began.

Fewer interruptions is exactly what shrank the gap between what they predicted and what they finished. [Source 4](#)

What you're not admitting about the plan

KNOW

Running past a weekend doesn't mean you're **disorganized**. Even people who finish everything else early run into this.

The pattern shows up as much in small chores as in massive infrastructure builds. [Source 1](#)

DON'T

Don't treat the date you say out loud to someone else as your real plan. People's spoken predictions ran more optimistic, and less accurate, than the ones they gave without their name attached.

Wanting to sound on top of things in front of someone else **skews the number** more than the job itself does. [Source 5](#)

Sources

1. <https://spsp.org/news-center/character-context-blog/planning-fallacy-inside-view>
2. <https://thedecisionlab.com/biases/planning-fallacy>
3. https://web.mit.edu/curhan/www/docs/Articles/biases/67_J_Personality_and_Social_Psychology_366,_1994.pdf
4. https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Planning_fallacy
5. https://digitalcommons.usf.edu/fac_publications/1230/

Read it online, with the rest of the set

This page is one of the Life Skills pages on Moving house at CheatGrid. Each one pairs a short cheat sheet of sourced findings with a checklist of the steps you'd otherwise forget.

[Open on cheatgrid.com](#)